

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

My Frugal Lord

How do you downsize your life? In his classic, *Walden*, philosopher Henry Thoreau reflects on his two-year self-exile to gauge the benefits of simple living. For many people, it's an idea whose time has come. Not exile, but downsizing lifestyles courtesy the economic meltdown. In corporatespeak, its termed downsizing, the lifestyle version is called downshifting. Faced with financial uncertainty, most middle-class Indians are muddle-class Indians, caught between having to give up the extravagant lifestyle they chose when the going was good, and acting like nothing has changed. We are all products of our environment and peer pressure plays a major role in deciding how we live. The subliminal seduction of advertising and the desire to show we are still financially well-off can be a powerful incentive for make-believe. It's easier to live a role, with the right house, the right car, the exotic holiday than to take a reality check, or rather a reality cheque, and tell your wife and kids, let's slow down, downshift from cruising in fifth gear to second gear, cut back on things that defined who we were pretending to be. Most people don't choose their lives, they choose their lifestyles. Many of my friends and close acquaintances flit through life, as Shakespeare says in *King Lear*, like "gilded butterflies", and for them, downshifting is a huge crisis of identity.

Now that economic reality has forcibly imposed limits on your lifestyle, it's time to ask one relevant question: "How much of your life is consumed by your lifestyle?" In most cases, the answer would be 'quite a lot'. Many people I know have used this period of economic uncertainty in a positive way: to step back and identify what areas of their life are an artificial choice and focus more on areas that are most important, family, home, friends, the joy of intimate, meaningful conversation and contact. Most important, by cutting out on frills and fancies, you realise what you have missed. It's a question of who adds joy and meaning to your life as opposed to those who merely entertain. Having a life, or a lifestyle, is a seduction. Psychologists believe that the most rapid personal development occurs when you have the time, space and reserves to allow you to experiment with new ways of thinking, working and living.

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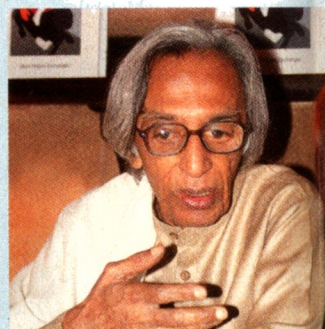


SAURABH SINGH

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Dr Joseph Kariyil as the 35th Bishop of Kochi, Kerala. He takes over from John Thattunkal, who was suspended by the Vatican following his decision to adopt a 39-year-old woman as his daughter.

DIED: Artist Tyeb Mehta, 84, whose painting *Celebration* was auctioned at Christie's for Rs 1.5 crore in 2002, breaking the Rs 1-crore barrier for a painting by an



GAMAR SIBTAIN

Indian. He was best known for using diagonals in his works and for his modern interpretations of mythological figures.

APPOINTED: Vinod Kumar Sachdeva as the first Indian ambassador to Niger. He is currently a minister in the high commission of India in Ottawa, Canada.

WON: By grandmaster P. Magesh Chandra, the Montcada Open Chess Championship in Montcada, Spain.

DIED: Gati Krushna Mishra, 97, former chief justice of the Orissa High Court from 1969-75.